

Contemporaneous meeting notes for use with other resources in preparation of draft minutes
MEMBERS – PERSONS appearing – BRIEF DESCRIPTION – DECISIONS. RSA 91-A:2.

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, March 13, 2026, in the Claremont Savings Bank Conference Room.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Girard at 8:00 a.m.

Members of the Council present:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O’Hearne – arrived at 10:30am

Ward II Councilor William Greenrose

Ward III Councilor Christopher Irish

Assistant Mayor Debora Matteau

At-Large Councilor Christopher Cogswell

At-Large Councilor Wayne Hemingway

At-Large Councilor William Limoges

At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski

Mayor Dale Girard

Also present:

Nancy Bates, City Manager

Shannon Thibodeau, Human Resource Director

Jim Chamberlain, Fire Chief

Brent Wilmot, Police Chief

NEW BUSINESS

COUNCIL WORK SESSION – GOALS AND OBJECTIVES

Carl Weber, Deputy City Manager of Portsmouth, New Hampshire hosted a goal and objectives work session for the City Council meeting to establish short- and long-term goals that will move Claremont forward.

The Council along with Mr. Weber started with ground rules and intentions. Next was the City of Claremont Vision where the Councilors wrote down what they wanted for the future of Claremont. Some of these included growth, better communication, a vital downtown, innovative solutions, being proactive about businesses and industry.

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The following step to this work session was called (ABN) Identification: Assets, Boundaries and Narrative. Mr. Weber asked the Council to share what they thought were assets of Claremont, some of these included people, recreation, safety, affordable housing, infrastructure, historical pride, development, employees, Amtrack, the municipal airport, the arts community like the Opera House, and Makerspace, and location.

Mr. Weber then asked Council to share what they thought were some boundaries for Claremont. Some of these included Negativity and misinformation, population size, and residents thinking the City controls the school budget. Property taxes, Council overreach, the school district, costly energy, limited work force availability like large manufacturers looking for workers, low-income population, vacant property, stigma and tax perception, limited funding and declining infrastructure, homelessness and recovery communities.

Mr. Weber then asked the Council what the story to the City is. Narratives that were shared included negative perception and tainted reputation, low income, schools being bad, taxes, homelessness, poor roads, being stuck in the past, infrastructure and roads. Other narratives included outdoor recreation, being a hard-working community and a great place to raise a family.

Mr. Weber added that being a city is an unexpected advantage and gave an example that as a city zoning regulations can be changed with a few public hearings.

Mr. Weber made note that a lot of these were past and future but wants the Council to think about how the city exists today, and needs a narrative that is consistent and present.

With all the input from the Council it was time to move on to ABN Reimagined, and how it can help the City reach its goals.

Assets Reimagined

Council shared what their reimagined assets are such as the industrial parks and how there is room for development. City employees not being utilized correctly or not appreciated enough. The Opera House with a suggestion to modernize. Schools and the need for them to be restructured, more development and to increase the tax base. Water-way access, downtown reimagined to be an arts and dining destination, creative zoning, farming, the Community College, and the Tech Center.

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Boundaries Reimagined

Some suggestions were a streamlined permitting process, being more development aggressive. Being a cheerleader for the City to combat negativity even if the city is on the losing side of an issue, improving business and zoning ordinances, getting the recovery community into the workforce, Council focusing on progress over process but understanding process is important. Enhance the tech center, and the relationship between the school and the city, reviewing and revising the City Charter.

Narratives reimagined – the following were some narratives reimagined by Council:

- Community Strong and United
- It's good to be a city
- Claremont, yes Claremont.
- Lively, Fragrant, and Growing
- Changing the narrative from there is nothing to do in the City.
- Speak highly of our employees and infrastructure.
- Re-establishing neighborhoods and encouraging owner occupancy.

GOALS:

Mr. Weber then started an exercise where each Councilor lists three goals that could be accomplished in the next 12-24 months. These were put up on boards and after all were listed the Council had a chance to move their goals to different boards to create broad categories.

After this the Council and the City Manager along with her Core Group were split into groups where each group would be assigned a board with the listed goals and would have to name the goal category, provide a summary on what the accomplishment is, then come up with two strategic objectives. This provides a clear map on what will happen, when will the goal be completed and who is responsible.

ADJOURNMENT

At 1:30p.m., a motion was made by Councilor Hemingway and seconded by Councilor Limoges to adjourn.

Voice vote:

O'Hearne – yes

Cogswell – yes

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Greenrose – yes

Matteau – yes

Koloski – yes

Limoges – yes

Hemingway – yes

Irish – yes

Girard – yes

Motion carried 9-0

Respectfully Submitted,

Julia A. Bizzarro

Clerk to the Council